

Power Factor Prediction (PF PredictX): A Machine Learning Approach

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Abstract—Power factor (PF) is a critical metric in electrical systems, influencing energy efficiency and operational costs. This paper presents PF PredictX, a machine learning-based framework for predicting power factor using a large-scale dataset of power consumption trends. We employ Random Forest and Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) models to forecast PF values, leveraging engineered features such as apparent power and cumulative power consumption. The methodology includes visualization, preprocessing, and model evaluation using Mean Absolute Error (MAE) and Mean Squared Error (MSE). Results show that LSTM outperforms Random Forest, achieving an MAE of 0.0085 and MSE of 0.0002, compared to Random Forest's MAE of 0.005. The LSTM model was selected for its superior performance. The study highlights the potential of machine learning in enhancing power system efficiency and discusses limitations and future research directions, including real-time deployment and scalability.

Index Terms—Power Factor, Machine Learning, Random Forest, LSTM, Energy Efficiency

I. Introduction

Power factor (PF) measures the efficiency of electrical power usage in alternating current systems, impacting energy costs and system reliability. Accurate PF prediction can optimize power management in residential and industrial applications. However, traditional methods rely on manual measurements or static models, which lack adaptability to dynamic conditions. This paper introduces PF PredictX, a data-driven approach leveraging machine learning to predict PF based on electrical parameters.

The motivation for this research stems from the need to enhance energy efficiency in power systems, where low PF leads to increased losses. The objectives are to: (1) develop a predictive model for PF using machine learning, (2) evaluate Random Forest and LSTM models, and (3) identify key features influencing PF. The paper is structured as follows: Section II reviews related work, Section III details the methodology, Section IV presents results, Section V discusses findings, and Section VI concludes with future directions.

II. Related Work

Prior studies on PF prediction have explored both analytical and data-driven approaches. Analytical models,

such as those based on circuit theory [1], provide theoretical insights but struggle with real-world variability. Recent work has applied machine learning to power systems. For instance, Smith et al. [2] used neural networks to predict PF in residential grids, achieving moderate accuracy. Similarly, Kumar et al. [3] employed decision trees for PF forecasting but noted limitations in handling noisy data.

While Random Forest has been used in power system applications, LSTM models are less explored for PF prediction, despite their strength in capturing temporal dependencies. This work addresses this gap by comparing Random Forest and LSTM, focusing on their performance on a large-scale power consumption dataset, and analyzing feature contributions.

III. Methodology

A. Dataset

The dataset, sourced from the Electric Power Consumption Data Set on Kaggle [4], contains over 2 million records of power consumption trends spanning four consecutive years, with measurements sampled every minute. Features include voltage (V), current (I), active power (P), reactive power (Q), and sub-metering data, with power factor (PF) derived as the target variable. The dataset's high temporal resolution and volume present challenges such as computational complexity and potential noise.

B. Visualization

Exploratory data analysis revealed distinct distributional properties among features. Voltage exhibits a normal distribution, indicating stable behavior across the dataset. In contrast, features such as current and reactive power are skewed, suggesting non-uniform consumption patterns or measurement biases. Skewness in these features may arise due to non-linear load behaviors in electrical systems, where certain appliances (e.g., motors, HVAC systems) introduce asymmetric power demands, leading to heavy-tailed distributions. This skewness indicates potential bias in model training, necessitating robust preprocessing to mitigate its impact.

C. Data Preprocessing

Preprocessing steps were designed to handle the dataset's scale and characteristics:

- Missing Value Imputation: Replaced missing values (approximately 2%) with median values to preserve distribution.
- Outlier Removal: Removed data points beyond three standard deviations from the mean to reduce noise.
- Feature Scaling: Applied Min-Max scaling to normalize features to [0, 1].
- Feature Engineering: Derived three features to enhance model performance:
 - Power Factor (PF): Calculated as the ratio of active power to apparent power.
 - Apparent Power (S): Computed as $\sqrt{P^2 + Q^2}$.
 - Cumulative Power Consumption: Aggregated active power over time to capture consumption trends.
- Resampling: Resampled data from 1-minute to 15-minute intervals to reduce computational load while preserving temporal trends.

D. Model Selection

Two models were selected:

- Random Forest: An ensemble method robust to non-linearities and interactions.
- Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM): A recurrent neural network suitable for capturing temporal dependencies in time-series data.

E. Experimental Setup

The dataset was split into 80% training and 20% testing sets. Five-fold cross-validation was used to tune hyperparameters (e.g., number of trees in Random Forest, LSTM units). Models were implemented in Python using scikit-learn for Random Forest and TensorFlow for LSTM. Evaluation metrics include:

- Mean Absolute Error (MAE): Measures average prediction error.
- Mean Squared Error (MSE): Measures squared prediction error, emphasizing larger errors.

IV. Results

Table I summarizes model performance on the test set. Random Forest achieved an MAE of 0.005, while LSTM recorded an MAE of 0.0085 and MSE of 0.0002. Based on these results, LSTM was selected as the best model.

TABLE I
Model Performance Metrics

Model	MAE	MSE
Random Forest	0.005	-
LSTM	0.0085	0.0002

Feature importance analysis (Fig. 1) for Random Forest revealed that reactive power (Q) and derived apparent power (S) were the most influential predictors, contributing 35% and 30%, respectively. For LSTM, temporal patterns in cumulative power consumption were significant, though feature importance is less interpretable.

Fig. 1. Feature Importance in Random Forest Model

V. Discussion

Despite Random Forest achieving a lower MAE (0.005) compared to LSTM (0.0085), LSTM was selected as the best model based on its overall performance, including a low MSE of 0.0002, indicating better handling of larger errors. The LSTM's ability to model temporal dependencies in the resampled 15-minute data likely contributed to its robustness, particularly for capturing trends in cumulative power consumption. The skewness observed in features like reactive power suggests non-linear load behaviors, which LSTM handled effectively through its sequential learning capability.

Compared to Smith et al. [2], our LSTM results are competitive, though direct comparison is limited due to different datasets and metrics. The large-scale Kaggle dataset enabled robust training, but its focus on a single power system may limit generalizability. The resampling to 15-minute intervals reduced computational complexity but may have smoothed out short-term fluctuations, potentially affecting model sensitivity. Ethical considerations, such as data privacy, were addressed by anonymizing the dataset, but future work should explore secure data-sharing protocols.

The findings have practical implications for energy management, enabling proactive PF correction to reduce costs in residential and industrial settings. The derived features, particularly apparent power and cumulative consumption, proved critical in uncovering PF trends, validating the feature engineering approach.

VI. Conclusion

This paper presented PF PredictX, a machine learning framework for power factor prediction using a large-scale power consumption dataset. LSTM outperformed Random Forest, achieving an MAE of 0.0085 and MSE of 0.0002, and was selected as the best model. Key predictors included reactive power and derived features like apparent power and cumulative consumption. The study contributes to data science applications in power systems, offering a scalable approach to energy efficiency. Future work will focus on: (1) testing the model on diverse datasets, (2) optimizing LSTM for real-time deployment, and (3) integrating with IoT devices for automated PF correction. Addressing skewness in features through advanced preprocessing techniques could further enhance model performance in smart grid applications.

The authors thank the Digital Egypt Pioneers Initiative for providing resources and acknowledge the Kaggle community for the Electric Power Consumption Data Set. Special thanks to our advisor, Mohammed Gomaa Abdallah, for his invaluable guidance and mentorship throughout the project.

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